

The food was wonderful and wouldn't have embarrassed the chef at "21" or the Four Seasons. There were ice sculptures on the dining room table (swans, not bulls), succulent little squabs dressed in pastel hula skirts, huge slabs of salmon with slices of cucumber stuck on to resemble the fish's own scales, and a French/Italian/California wine list as long as a good English novel. We ate while looking at a duck pond.

At that first meal I met several of the trainees and their professors, an affable bunch. Most were bright and well spoken, though some had come straight from the unemployment lines. There was a poet from Southern California, Lance Jencks, who'd been laid off as an 800-line telephone jockey for oil-and-gas leasing schemes. There was a 250-pound ex-football player who used to sell insurance. There were a few ex-car dealers (one, Paul from Wichita, said that investments were just "another vehicle"), a computer salesman or two, a rancher, a ballet dancer, a man who'd burned out on wheat futures, a "syndicator" with nothing left to syndicate, plus some former schoolteachers. Of the 150 in the group, I counted 25 women, 1 black, and the rest white males aged 26 to 60. Of the white males, at least 15 were out-of-work Texans.

After dinner, I watched trainees play billiards until they returned to their rooms to do homework, and then I swam laps alone in the giant indoor swimming pool. I didn't see them again until morning when classes began at 8:00. Since I'd been given a badge that got me past the numerous guards, I could roam freely from place to place. Once in a while a conference director would take me aside to ask me my impressions so far.

The first class I entered was fitted out like a language lab, with phones installed on each desk. These phones were connected to similar phones in the next room, so recruits could call back and forth to practice whatever they were learning. Soon, the phones started ringing and I listened to some conversations that would remind you of *La Familia de Tio Pepe*, if you've ever taken Spanish. These dialogues were in English. I copied one from the training manual, to give you the flavor.

Dr. MacIntyre, good morning. This is Terry Harper at Merrill Lynch. How are you today?